

Take, for example, the pompous—and obviously job-seeking—executive who cornered me recently at a cocktail party. He complained bitterly that he had been passed over for promotion twice by the well-known firm for which he worked.

"I'm a victim of company politics," he declared, obviously believing it. "There's no other explanation. I've always performed my duties exactly as an executive should!"

"And how is that?" I inquired, my curiosity to hear what weird theories he'd propound getting the better of my good judgment.

"I keep a tight rein on the people in my department. I never let them put anything over on me or the company. If they try, I fire them on the spot!" the man replied with smug pride. "I don't question my orders and always carry them out to the letter, regardless of the consequences."

At this point, I suddenly pretended that I'd just recognized a long-lost relative across the room, disengaged myself and beat a rapid retreat. I'd heard all I cared to hear—

or could stomach.

I can readily understand why this so-called executive hadn't been promoted. What I can't understand is why he

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hadn't been given the sack long before. Certainly, he wouldn't remain on my payroll for five minutes. He personifies the two worst qualities anyone holding down a responsible managerial job in a modern business firm could possibly possess. His attitude toward his subordinates is clearly that of a slave-driving martinet. His attitude toward his superiors—at least to their faces—is just as clearly that of a complete bootlicker utterly devoid of imagination or common sense.

Let's look at it this way. Business management may be broadly defined as the art of directing human activities so as to carry out a business firm's